Houston ISD AI Guidebook: Data and Student Privacy Passages

Excerpted verbatim from *Houston ISD AI Guidebook, Version 2 (Houston Independent School District, last updated January 23, 2026)*. Page numbers match the document's own page numbering. Ellipses (…) mark omitted text. Passages marked [graphic] were transcribed from multi-column or table layouts in the original that the text extraction jumbled.

Introduction (excerpt)

Source: page 3 [graphic]

[graphic] By proactively addressing concerns around data privacy, academic integrity, age-appropriate access, and ethical AI development and use, the district aims to harness the benefits of this transformative technology while mitigating risks.

[graphic] The district prioritizes the safety and security of our students and staff alongside the opportunity for engagement with technology of the future.

Our “Why” and Future Aspirations: Opportunities (excerpt)

Source: page 4 [graphic]

- [graphic] Students below 8th grade will engage with generative AI Chatbots through teacher modeling only. Furthermore, they can interact with educational tools with AI capabilities, such as Amira or Microsoft Reading Coach
- [graphic] Students 8th grade and above who have parental consent will engage with generative AI Chatbots in both a Teacher-guided and/or supervised manner

District Initiatives to Increase AI Literacy: FutureReady Cohort (excerpt)

Source: page 5

The training ensures all staff understand the district’s overall AI strategy and implementation , covering critical areas such as defining GenAI, discussing its ethical implications, exploring use guidelines, and prioritizing safety and privacy concerns.

Houston ISD Generative AI Guiding Principles: Focusing on Safety & Privacy

Source: page 7 [graphic]

[graphic] Focusing on Safety & Privacy

[graphic] AI use must align with existing regulations to protect student data privacy, including federal laws such as the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) and the Children’s Online Privacy Protection Act (COPPA). We will not share personally identifiable information with consumer-based AI systems and will ensure parental consent for student use.

[graphic] To uphold evaluation, accountability, and transparency with generative AI, Houston ISD will implement clear processes to monitor and analyze AI outputs for accuracy, track AI usage data, and require proper disclosure when AI tools are leveraged for assignments or content creation.

Generative AI Use Guidelines for All Stakeholders

Source: page 8 [graphic]

[graphic] The following five core guidelines serve as mandatory standards that all stakeholders within the district, including faculty, staff, and students, must adhere to when engaging with generative AI platforms. These guidelines are essential safeguards designed to protect individual privacy, maintain data security, combat inaccuracy and bias, and uphold academic and professional integrity.

[graphic] Five General Core Use Guidelines For All Stakeholders: Students and Staff

[graphic] **01 Keep Data Private:** Students and staff should use enterprise-level generative AI tools. If staff elect to use consumer-based AI platforms, staff should never input personal, sensitive or confidential data into any system.

[graphic] **02 Ensure Parental Consent:** Maintain awareness of age restrictions on generative AI tools, as some restrict usage to those 18 years of age and older, while others permit access from age 13 with parental consent. Ensure parental consent has been obtained and documented before using these tools.

[graphic] **03 Use Secure Devices and Vetted Programs:** Use secure devices when accessing AI tools. Make sure the device you are using is protected with the latest security updates, firewalls, and antivirus software. Furthermore, staff and students should use only approved generative AI tools and programs (See the list of approved programs on page 15).

Generative AI Use Guidelines for Students (excerpt)

Source: page 9 [graphic]

[graphic] Students below 8th grade are prohibited from accessing generative AI tools on school devices or networks, with the exception of district approved educational tools that incorporate artificial intelligence technology (i.e. Amira Learning and Microsoft Reading Coach). Although teachers may choose to utilize GenAI tools in the classroom for instruction or demonstration purposes, students below 8th grade shall have no direct, unsupervised access to the technology on Houston ISD networks or devices.

[graphic] Students 8th grade and above may access generative AI tools for approved educational purposes under the following conditions:

- [graphic] **Parental Consent:** Parents/Guardians must provide written consent allowing their child to access generative AI tools for educational use.
- [graphic] **Teacher Permission:** The student must receive prior approval from their teacher outlining the permitted educational task(s) for each use of generative AI.
- [graphic] **Responsible and Ethical Use:** Students must use generative AI responsibly at all times, adhering to all district technology usage policies.

[graphic] I cannot… (8th grade and above)

- [graphic] Access generative AI tools without parent/guardian consent and teacher approval for each use.

- [graphic] Use generative AI in a way that violates data privacy, academic integrity, or district policies.

[graphic] Personal vs. School Use

[graphic] Houston ISD reserves the right to monitor student use of generative AI on its devices and networks. Violations of district use guidelines, as outlined below, may result in disciplinary action.

Student Use Guidelines: Safety & Responsible Use

Source: page 11 [graphic]

[graphic] Students must use generative AI tools in a safe, responsible manner that protects the privacy and well-being of themselves and others. Under no circumstances should students input personally identifiable information (PII) about themselves, classmates, teachers, or any other individuals into an AI system. This includes (but is not limited to):

- [graphic] Full names
- [graphic] Addresses
- [graphic] Phone numbers
- [graphic] ID numbers

Generative AI Use Guidelines for Staff: Staff Use Guidelines (excerpt)

Source: page 13 [graphic]

[graphic] Supervise Student Access & Use

- [graphic] Ensure students have obtained proper parental consent prior to providing students access to district approved generative AI tools
- [graphic] Monitor use frequently and address flags for inappropriate use (refer to guidance on consequences in Student Table)

[graphic] Prioritize Safety and Data Security

- [graphic] Never enter personally identifiable information (PII) into an AI tool. The definition of what constitutes PII can be found in Board Policy FL (Local).
- [graphic] Review and comply with the district's Acceptable Use Guidelines for all AI tools used in the classroom
- [graphic] Do not use unvetted AI tools without confirming FERPA and COPPA compliance
- [graphic] Explicitly teach students to protect their own data privacy when using generative AI

A Note on Approved AI Tools for Classroom and Instructional Use

Source: page 14

Teachers are prohibited from using any other generative AI tools directly with students unless the tool has gone through the district's vetting and approval process.

The IT department will thoroughly vet the proposed tool for safety, privacy, accuracy, accessibility and alignment with curriculum standards before granting approval.

[graphic] Staff Use of AI for Personal Productivity

However, staff are required to maintain rigorous privacy and security practices when using AI tools that may involve any student or staff data. Violations of data privacy policies may result in disciplinary action consistent with district procedures.

Consequences for Improper Use: Staff (excerpt)

Source: page 15 [graphic]

[graphic] Teacher violates student privacy by entering personally identifiable information (PII) into an AI tool — Mandatory retraining on data privacy and district technology policies. Notification of the AI Support Team: AI_Support_Team@houstonisd.org

Houston ISD Vetted Generative AI Tools List

Source: pages 16–17

HISD uses a federated AI approach—deploying different AI platforms for different purposes (such as reasoning, workflow automation, or curriculum support). This ensures stronger security, avoids vendor lock-in, and allows each tool to operate within the most appropriate protected environment.

[graphic] ChatGPT and Microsoft Copilot are powered by OpenAI's GPT models while Google Gemini is powered by Google's Gemini models. These generative AI tools sit within the Houston ISD domain. They are enterprise generative AI tools, which means that chat history is not used to train the models. We highly recommend these tools above as an alternative to the consumer versions of the AI tools. HISD has signed Data Sharing Agreements with OpenAI, Google, and Microsoft.

[graphic] Microsoft 365 Copilot — Rationale for Selection: This generative AI tool sits within the Houston ISD domain and plugs into the Microsoft suite of productivity tools including Word, Powerpoint, Teams, and Outlook. Through the plug-in, the tool has access to all data stored within the Microsoft suite of programs and can answer questions using that data as an input. It is an enterprise generative AI tool, which means that any sensitive data that is shared with this tool does not get shared back with the AI for training purposes.

Monitoring Tools and Processes

Source: page 18 [graphic]

[graphic] To ensure the responsible and secure implementation of generative AI across the District, HISD employs preventative controls designed to block the movement of sensitive data before exposure occurs, in addition to monitoring and alerting mechanisms.

[graphic] **Data Loss Prevention** — Flags movement of sensitive data

[graphic] **Pop-Up Notification when users access consumer-based AI platforms** — Reinforces organization's acceptable use guidelines, especially when dealing with Consumer-based AI tools

[graphic] **Usage Tracking Software** — Provides IT with visibility into user traffic to AI-powered web tools to inform updated user support and policy

[graphic] **AI Support Team Referral Form** — A mechanism for staff to refer issues to the AI Support and Data Governance Team. Issues include but are not limited to:

- [graphic] Inappropriate Student or Staff Use

- [graphic] Requests for new tools
- [graphic] Request for a pilot
- [graphic] Data Breach

AI Support Team Overview and AI in Board Policy (excerpt)

Source: page 19 [graphic]

[graphic] Key Monitoring responsibilities include:

- [graphic] Reviewing usage tracking reports to understand organizational access to generative AI platforms
- [graphic] Monitoring security / data breaches collected through loss prevention software and determine appropriate response

[graphic] **FL** — This policy clarifies the importance of protecting personally identifiable information, especially when using generative AI tools

Frequently Asked Questions: Students (excerpt)

Source: page 20

What happens if my parent or guardian does not provide permission for me to use generative AI?

We respect the decisions that parents or guardians make for their children. If you are not given permission to access generative AI, your teacher will work with you to make sure you have the support you need to learn and complete your assignments.

Frequently Asked Questions: Staff (excerpt)

Source: page 21

How do I know which of my students has permission to access generative AI?

The Central Office team will manage student access to generative AI tools based on age and parental consent. Additionally, each campus is responsible for keeping a record of parent permission decisions granted for AI tool usage. Before a teacher brings generative AI into the classroom, please ensure that you review student permission.

Do I have to use Microsoft Copilot Chat, Google Gemini, or ChatGPT Edu? Can I use generative AI Chatbots that I've paid for myself to support my work?

We highly recommend our staff not use consumer chatbots for work-related activities. Sensitive data is not protected in a way that complies with FERPA policy. For example, if you uploaded a data file into your personal ChatGPT for analysis that includes student ID numbers and names, you have now violated HISD Data privacy policies. Microsoft Copilot Chat, Google Gemini, and ChatGPT Edu reside within the HISD domain and protects sensitive data. We trust that our employees will use their best efforts to access the enterprise-level generative AI tools to support their efficiency and productivity in a way that keeps district data private and secure.

How is AI used in Houston ISD, and is it considered a system of record?

AI tools in Houston ISD are not systems of record and function only as professional planning and drafting environments. All AI-assisted work is pre-decisional, requires human review, and any finalized or official materials must be stored in HISD-approved systems (e.g., email, SharePoint, OneDrive, SIS, ERP).

Frequently Asked Questions: Families

Source: page 22

Are generative AI tools appropriate for my child, especially if they are 8th grade or above?

Generative AI tools have different age restrictions. At this time, Houston ISD will provide access to Google Gemini to students, 8th grade and above who have obtained parental consent. The district will prioritize responsible use training for both students and staff as well as support students if content is returned that is inappropriate.

Is my student's data protected while using generative AI tools?

Student data protection is a top priority in Houston ISD. If a student uses consumer-based AI tools (such as public versions of ChatGPT) outside of district-managed platforms, any information entered may be shared with the company that operates the tool.

Houston ISD provides access to secure, district-managed AI environments, including the enterprise version of Google Gemini for staff and students ages 13 and older. These tools do not use student or staff data to train external AI models and operate within HISD's security and privacy requirements, including access controls, monitoring, and safeguards designed to prevent the exposure or misuse of sensitive information.